

INTRODUCTION

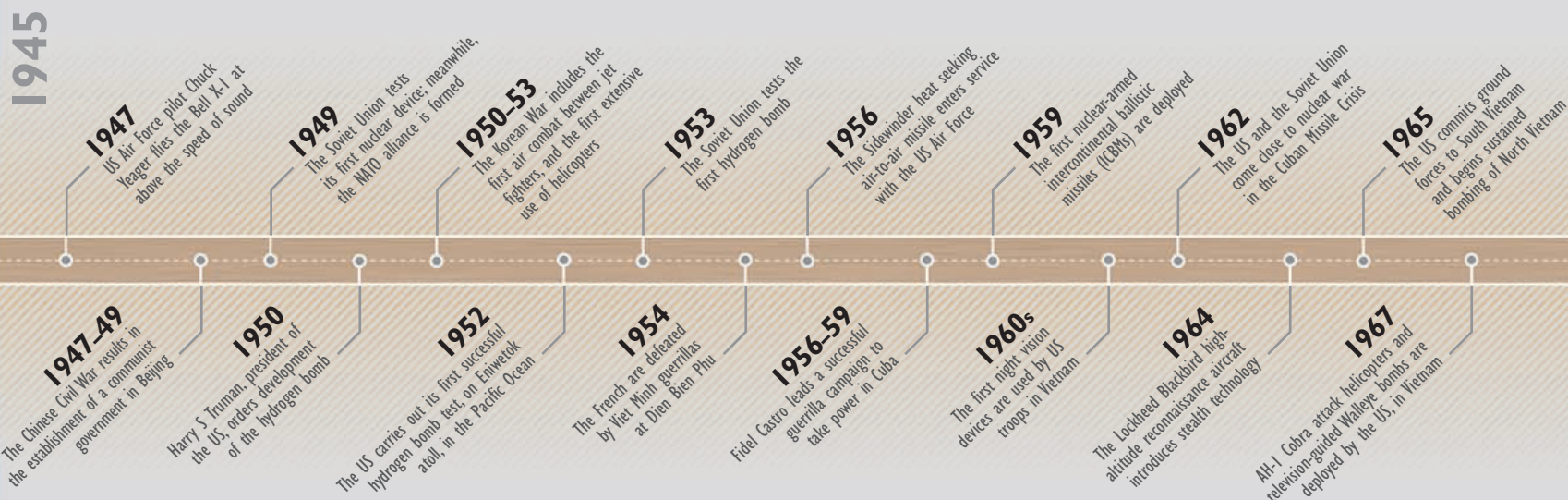
After World War II, developments in military technology were driven by the Cold War confrontation between the two “superpowers” – the United States and the Soviet Union. At the same time, guerrilla warfare and terrorism have proved enduringly resistant to the world’s most advanced military arsenals.

From the late 1940s, a nuclear arms race between the US-led NATO alliance and the Soviet Union created weaponry of awesome destructive power. With long-range bombers replaced by missiles as nuclear delivery systems, by the 1960s the world had entered the era of MAD – Mutually Assured Destruction. Peace between the superpowers was maintained by the certainty of unbearable losses in the event of a nuclear war. At the same time, each side sought to surpass the other in every area of conventional military technology, from the performance of aircraft and submarines, to guidance

systems and military satellites. Although World War III never materialized, much of the non-nuclear technology was tried out in the 1960s and 1970s, in wars between Israel and its Arab neighbours, and by the US in Vietnam. However, it was the 1991 Gulf War – the first major post-Cold War conflict – that revealed the true scale of technological progress, showcasing such wonders as smart bombs, stealth aircraft, and cruise missiles.

The post-WWII era has also seen the rise of guerrilla warfare and terrorism. Although they generally lack access to advanced weaponry, guerrillas have benefited from modern infantry weaponry and explosives, while the arms industry has fuelled low-level conflicts across the globe with a ready supply of automatic weapons and ammunition. Despite the fact that technological progress made the need for a mass citizen army outdated by the end of the 20th century, when major powers fought guerrilla forces, they found there was no alternative to putting troops on the ground and sustaining the losses this entailed.

KEY DATES



NUCLEAR BUNKER, MOSCOW – 1956



OPERATION CEDAR FALLS – 1967



THE APACHE HELICOPTER – 1984

